

tally come across the building, I wouldn't have known there was a Fed in New York.

Inside the huge, steel-studded double doors was a giant hallway. Except for a metal detector at one end and a statue of a depraved-looking Young Sophocles at the other, it was empty. To the right of the statue was an arch that led to a promenade of video screens where continuous taped lectures were shown. From these lectures, I learned there are twelve Fed districts, that Fed headquarters is in Washington, that the organization regulates the money supply, oversees numerous banking matters, shreds old bills and replaces them with new ones, and clears one-third of all checks written on local banks across the nation.

This particular New York Fed had 200 alarms, a security staff the size of a metropolitan police force (the exact number of security guards was kept classified for security reasons), a bowling alley, a firing range, and a gym. On the wall above my head was chiseled the inspirational Fed motto: TO FURNISH AN ELASTIC CURRENCY.

While loitering around the educational archway, I witnessed a curious, impromptu procession. Through the various displays scurried a pair, then two pairs, and finally a mob of young men in tweed overcoats and with pasty winter complexions, swinging their briefcases like brakemen's lanterns. They were on a mission that so completely absorbed them that when I asked one of the men what he was doing, he mumbled "Salomon Brothers" and jogged along toward a distant anteroom.

I followed, watching intently as the Salomon man and his tweedy cohorts scrambled across a wooden dolly piled with telephones. Each of them picked up a telephone, carried it out to a long bank of waist-high cubicles, and plugged it into a waiting plastic jack.

The instant the connections were made, the phones started ringing and the mob that installed them lifted the receivers. Nothing much was said from this end. Mostly, the men listened and took notes.

Soon one or two of them left the phones and strolled across the room toward what looked like a primitive metal ballot box, the kind used in rural elections. Next to the box was a punch clock, controlled by a woman who sat on a highchair. As the men shoved large manila envelopes into the ballot box, this woman handed